

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN THE SOLOMON ISLANDS

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action decides project outcomes in the Solomon Islands, and one small island proved it against a foreign mining company and its own government's approval. On **Wagina Island** — a remote place of some two thousand people in Choiseul Province, who live by fishing, seaweed farming, and their gardens — a company owned out of Hong Kong, **Solomon Bauxite Limited**, held government approval to dig an open-pit bauxite mine that would have swallowed **sixty percent of the island**, cleared two thousand hectares of forest, and run a hundred and fifty truckloads a day for twenty years, destroying the land, the rivers, and the sea the community lived on. The people of Wagina refused. They fought from 2013, and with the help of legal aid from the Public Solicitor's office and an environmental legal team, they brought their case to the country's **Environmental Advisory Committee**. In 2019, for the first time in the nation's history, that committee **revoked the company's development consent** — because the company had never obtained the community's genuine consent, and had hidden its environmental impact statement from the people it would affect. When the company appealed, the **Minister of the Environment, in 2020, dismissed the appeal**. A remote island community, with nothing but its unity and the law properly used, had stopped a mine its own government had approved. The details are worth setting down, because they are the lessons. Wagina lies in the far northwest of the country, in Choiseul Province, an island of some seventy-eight square kilometres whose roughly two thousand people were themselves resettled there from Kiribati by the British administration in the early 1960s, and who live from the reef, the sea, and their gardens. The mine would have cleared two thousand hectares of forest, run its trucks sixteen hours a day for two decades, and stripped ore by the tens of billions of kilograms — and the run-off and the disturbance to the freshwater that seeps into the sea threatened the very fishing and seaweed farming the community lived on. Against all that, the people had one decisive fact on their side: they had never truly agreed, and the company had never shown them what it planned to do.

The Wagina fight teaches two things about winning in the Solomon Islands — including its hard limits, which this guide will not hide. The first is the pattern: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the customary landowners, the requirement of genuine consent, legal aid, the environmental process, international allies, and the media — pressed together until the consent was revoked and the appeal dismissed. The second is distinctly Solomon Islander. The decisive lever here is **customary land and the right to genuine consent**: the great majority of Solomon Islands land is held under **custom** by its people, and a project needs their **free, prior, and informed consent** — so a project that never truly won the community's agreement, or that hid its impacts, is legally and morally vulnerable, as Wagina proved. This principle — free, prior, and informed consent — is not a foreign import but the natural legal expression of a society where land is held by its people under custom, not owned by the state or bought and sold like a commodity. Because the great majority of Solomon Islands land belongs to customary landowners, a company cannot lawfully proceed simply by obtaining a government license; it must win the genuine agreement of the people whose land it is. That requirement is the single most powerful thing a Solomon Islands community holds, because so many projects are built on a “consent” that will not survive scrutiny. That, together with the **subsistence land-and-sea livelihoods** that make the island itself the community's life, gives people here real and distinctive power.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide states them plainly. The Solomon Islands' central problem is not the absence of laws but their **non-enforcement**, and above all the **corruption of the logging and mining industries**: licenses are granted on the basis of a single staged meeting, consent is faked, chiefs and landowners are divided and paid, and the vast logging trade has laid down thousands of kilometres of roads through the forests at a ruinous, unsustainable pace. This distinction — between laws that are missing and laws that are ignored — matters enormously to strategy, because it means a community's task is frequently not to invent a new protection but to force the existing one to work. The consent requirement, the environmental process, the impact statement: these exist on paper, and Wagina's achievement was to make them real by insisting, with legal help, that they be honoured. A campaign that understands this aims its energy not at wishing for better laws but at compelling the enforcement of the laws already there. The scale of the logging problem is hard to overstate: the country has more than twelve thousand kilometres of logging roads cut through its islands, timber has been harvested at rates far beyond what the forests can sustain, and the industry has become a byword for faked landowner consent, divided chiefs, and licenses granted with little regard for the law. It is against that backdrop — a resource sector where corruption is closer to the rule than the exception — that a community must fight, and it is why insisting the existing law actually be enforced is so often the heart of the battle. Wagina was a **hard-won victory that took seven years** and turned on a clear legal defect — and it was one win against

many losses. The **state is weak and remote**, and a community far from Honiara can struggle to reach the law without help. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of customary landowners who insist on genuine consent, and the corruption, division, and non-enforcement they must overcome.

Most communities do not know HOW to make opposition effective. They discover a logging or mining license already granted, assume "the company and the government have decided," and never insist on their right to genuine consent. They never challenge the fake consultation, never use legal aid or the environmental committee, never document the harm to the land and sea, never hold the landowners united against division, never draw the outside allies. They generate private anger without a legal and public campaign. The gap between a community that stops a project and one that watches it get built is rarely courage or numbers. It is method — and, above all, insisting the law be made to work.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Solomon Islands system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective opposition campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whichever project they face:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the decision and its weak point)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION          (build proof of harm and of every defect)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION       (unite the landowners and the community)
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES       (consent, the environmental committee, and the courts)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY         (make the fight national and international)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the legal case and the public argument at once; the united community sustains the pressure decision-makers respond to; a legal filing or an international appeal is a headline and a headline strengthens the community. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins. The Wagina campaign did exactly this — it documented the threat to the island, united the landowners, insisted on genuine consent, used the environmental committee with legal aid, and drew international attention, until the consent was revoked and the appeal dismissed.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. The Solomon Islands' give communities a distinctive set:

- **Customary land and genuine consent.** Most land is held under **custom**, and a project needs the landowners' **free, prior, and informed consent** — a fake or absent consent is a fatal defect, as it was at Wagina.
- **The Environmental Advisory Committee.** A formal body that can **revoke development consent** where the law was not followed — the lever that stopped the Wagina mine, with an appeal to the Minister. What made the Environmental Advisory Committee decisive at Wagina was that it looked past the government's own earlier approval to the legal defects beneath it: the company had not obtained the community's genuine consent, and it had kept its environmental impact statement from the very people it would affect. On those grounds the Committee revoked the consent — the first time in the country's history it had done so — and when the company appealed, the Minister of the Environment upheld the revocation. It is a channel that can undo even a project the state has already blessed, provided the community can show the law was not followed.
- **Legal aid and the Public Solicitor.** The Public Solicitor's **Landowners Advocacy and Legal Support Unit** and environmental legal teams give even a remote, poor community access to the law.
- **Subsistence land-and-sea livelihoods.** Fishing, gardens, and seaweed farming make the island and its waters the community's whole life, so a threat to them is a threat to survival.
- **International allies.** Environmental and human-rights organisations, drawn by the Pacific's ecology and by the treatment of communities, bring scrutiny and reach.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers work smoothly. The deepest problem is **non-enforcement and corruption**: licenses are granted on faked consent, officials and some chiefs are captured, and the logging industry in particular runs on division and bribery. **Communities are divided** — companies co-opt some landowners against others, exploiting disputes over who speaks for the land. The **state is weak and remote**, and reaching the law takes help. And Wagina was a **rare, hard-won win** among many losses, turning on a clear defect not every project has. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to fight anyway — insisting on genuine consent, uniting the landowners, using legal aid and the environmental committee, drawing outside allies, and pursuing the revoked consent, the delay, and the record that are often what progress actually looks like.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single weekend, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Solomon Islands development project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

Customary land and consent. Most land is **customary**, and a logging or mining project needs the landowners' agreement — obtained, in law, through a proper process of **consent and consultation**. This is the foundation, and where a project is most often legally defective, because consent is so often faked or forced. Understand what genuine consent requires, because the strategy follows from it: the landowners must be the true customary owners, not a convenient few; they must be told honestly and fully what the project will do, including through the environmental impact statement; and they must agree freely, without the pressure of a payment dangled or a threat implied. A "consent" that fails any of these tests — the wrong people, an uninformed people, a pressured people — is the flaw a community builds its whole case upon, and it is astonishing how often, once examined, the consent behind a project fails all three.

The license. Logging and mining turn on a **license or permit** granted centrally, by the relevant ministry — often, notoriously, on the basis of minimal or staged consultation.

Environmental consent and the Committee. Significant projects need **development consent** under the environmental law, and a refusal or revocation can be sought from, or appealed to, the **Environmental Advisory Committee** and the **Minister of the Environment** — the lever that stopped Wagina.

The provincial government. Provinces have roles in resource decisions and have sometimes acted to **ban or block** logging and mining, as one province did.

The courts. The courts, including the **High Court**, can review the legality of licenses, consents, and decisions, and enforce customary-land rights.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a **license**, through a claimed **consent and consultation** of the customary landowners, into **environmental development consent**, past the **provincial government**, into **the Environmental Advisory Committee and the courts** if challenged, with **community resistance** running alongside, before construction. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The earliest doors are the cheapest and widest: challenging the fake consent, uniting the landowners, documentation, and the environmental objection. The later doors — the Environmental Advisory Committee, an appeal to the Minister, a court challenge — are more demanding but real, and Wagina was won through the Committee and the Minister with legal aid. Find out exactly where your project stands on this path; that tells you which door is open now.

Follow the License, the Land, and the Consent

Behind the project stand a proponent — a foreign logging or mining company, its local agents, and its financiers — and the officials who granted the license. Trace who owns and funds the proponent, who profits, who granted the license, and — critically in the Solomon Islands — **whether the customary landowners genuinely consented, or the consent was faked, forced, or bought**, and **what the project does to the land, the forest, the rivers, and the sea the community lives on.** Two questions unlock most Solomon Islands fights: **Did the landowners genuinely consent — or is the consent a fraud?** and **What does it do to the land and sea the community survives on?** The defect in consent and the threat to the livelihoods are, together, the heart of most Solomon Islands campaigns. The two work together: the threat to the land and sea gives the community its reason to resist and to unite, and the defect in consent gives that resistance a legal edge that can actually stop the project. A campaign that documents the harm but ignores the consent may move hearts without moving the law; one that attacks the consent but cannot show what is at stake may win a technical point without rousing the community. Build both from the first day — the harm to the livelihoods and the fraud in the consent — and let each strengthen the other, as they did at Wagina.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies that watch the deciders, because they are levers too. The **Environmental Advisory Committee** and the **Minister** can revoke a consent; the **courts** review legality and customary rights; the **Public Solicitor's legal-aid**

unit helps communities reach them; the **provincial governments** can act; and the **international organisations and the press** watch over Pacific communities and ecosystems — the outside overseers who, at Wagina, amplified the fight. Among these, the environmental legal teams and international human-rights organisations proved especially important, because they combined the ability to reach documents and the Committee with the power to carry the story to the world — a remote island’s cause becoming, through them, a matter of international attention that a government could not simply set aside. In a system where enforcement is weak, the **Environmental Advisory Committee, legal aid, and international attention** are the levers that most reliably make the law work. Each is a separate front, and a project built on faked consent, threatening the land and sea, and challenged in the Committee and the courts rarely survives pressure on several at once. You do not have to choose one door: the same well-built file — the defect in consent, the hidden impact statement, the threat to land and sea — can go to the Environmental Advisory Committee, the courts, the international networks, the company’s owners, and the national public at once, and each front that opens makes the others harder to close. A Solomon Islands campaign’s power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together, with united landowners and the defect in consent as the two that reach furthest past a captured process.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Solomon Islands and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the **consent was genuinely obtained** or is defective, whether the **landowners can stay united** against division and payment, whether the community can **reach legal aid and the environmental committee**, whether the project threatens the **land and sea** the community survives on, and whether **international allies** can be drawn in. Where a defect in consent meets united landowners and legal aid, the Solomon Islands' levers are real, as Wagina proved; where the landowners are divided and the community cannot reach the law, discount the figures sharply.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	1-3 months	low	Basis for every other step
Challenging defective consent	30-55%	months-years	low	The project's foundation undone
Uniting the landowners	decisive	ongoing	low	The precondition for winning
Environmental Advisory Committee	25-55%	months-years	low-moderate	Development consent refused or revoked
Legal aid / court challenge	25-50%	months-years	low	License or consent overturned
Land-and-sea livelihoods argument	30-55%	ongoing	low	Community and national support
International & media appeal	30-55%	ongoing	low	Outside scrutiny; company pressure
Provincial action	case-specific	months	low	Local ban or block
Against a divided community / captured process	10-35%	years	low-moderate	Delay, scrutiny, partial gains
All steps combined (consent defect + unity)	40-65%	1-7 years	low-moderate	Consent revoked, stopped, or overturned
All steps combined (divided/captured)	15-35%	1-5 years	low-moderate	Delayed, scrutinised; record built

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and the Solomon Islands' real strengths are distinctive — **customary land and genuine consent**, the **Environmental Advisory Committee, legal aid**, the **land-and-sea livelihoods**, and **international allies**. Its constraints are severe and specific: **non-enforcement and corruption**, especially in logging; **division of landowners** by payment and dispute; a **weak, remote state**; and wins that are **hard-won and rare**.

A note on cost: challenging consent, uniting the landowners, and objecting on the environment cost little but organisation and courage. The Environmental Advisory Committee and the courts are reachable with legal aid — the Public Solicitor's unit and environmental legal teams work for communities, so cost need not bar the way, as it did not at Wagina. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is the patient work of uniting the landowners and insisting on genuine consent — exactly what carried Wagina through seven years.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (consent revoked, stopped, overturned, or delayed)

CONSENT DEFECT + UNITED LANDOWNERS -- faked consent, united community, legal aid reached:	
All steps combined:	40-65%
Challenging consent + EAC:	30-55%
Legal aid + courts:	25-50%
Livelihoods + international:	30-55%
Single step:	5-55%

DIVIDED COMMUNITY / CAPTURED PROCESS -- landowners split and paid, corrupt licensing:	
All steps combined:	15-35%
Delay / scrutiny / record:	more achievable than a clean stop
International + media:	the strongest outside leverage
Single step:	10-35%

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in the Solomon Islands are **the defect in consent, the united landowners, and legal aid reaching the Environmental Advisory Committee**, amplified by the livelihoods argument and international attention. Wagina shows the ceiling: united landowners, insisting on genuine consent and using legal aid, got a development consent revoked and an appeal dismissed. But corruption and division show the floor: where the landowners are split and paid and the process is captured, even a determined community may win only delay. Most Solomon Islands fights sit between these poles, and the honest lesson is that consent, unity, and legal aid are real and distinctive levers — decisive when the landowners hold together and the law is insisted upon, far weaker when they do not. Use the table to plan, not to predict: it tells you which combinations have historically done the most work and where to put scarce effort first. The single most important reading is that unity and consent are bound together — united landowners are what make a claim of "we never consented" credible and unshakable, while divided landowners let a company argue that some of them agreed; so the effort spent uniting the landowners is the same effort that strengthens the legal case, and it is never wasted.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Uniting the landowners** — the precondition for everything; a community the company cannot divide with payment and dispute is one that can win.
2. **The defect in consent** — the decisive legal lever; a faked, forced, or hidden consent is the flaw that undoes a project, as at Wagina.
3. **Legal aid and the Environmental Advisory Committee** — the reachable channel, through the Public Solicitor and environmental legal teams, that revokes a consent.
4. **The land-and-sea livelihoods** — the argument that the island and its waters are the community's whole life, which roots the fight and wins support.
5. **International attention and the courts** — the outside scrutiny and the legal challenge that amplify the fight and enforce the law.

What Solomon Islands Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Genuine consent is the key** — a project built on faked consent can be undone, as Wagina was. **Unity is everything** — a divided community loses; a united one wins. **Legal aid makes the law reachable** — the Public Solicitor and environmental teams carried Wagina. **The land and sea are life** — a threat to them roots the fight. **But corruption and non-enforcement are severe** — and wins are hard and rare. The through-line: **unite the landowners; challenge the faked or absent consent; reach legal aid and the Environmental Advisory Committee; make the land-and-sea-livelihoods argument; draw international attention; and know it may take years, as Wagina did.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and its weakest point. Vague opposition goes nowhere; opposition to "the bauxite mine approved for sixty percent of our island, on a consent the company faked and an impact statement it hid from us" is a case — the case that stopped the Wagina mine. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. **Did the landowners genuinely consent — or is the consent defective?** This is the first Solomon Islands question,

because customary land needs the landowners' **free, prior, and informed consent**, and a **faked, forced, hidden, or divided consent** is the flaw that most often undoes a project, as it undid Wagina's. Establish exactly how "consent" was claimed to be obtained.

2. What does it do to the land and sea the community survives on? Name the project and the specific harm — the forest, the rivers, the reefs, the fishing, the gardens, the seaweed farming — because the island and its waters are the community's whole life. In a place like Wagina, there is no separation between the land and the livelihood: the reef is the larder, the sea grows the seaweed that is sold for cash, the forest and gardens feed the families, and the freshwater beneath the ground keeps them all alive. A mine that would take sixty percent of such an island is not proposing to use some spare corner of it; it is proposing to consume the community's entire means of survival. Making that totality vivid — that the project takes not a resource but a whole way of living — is what unites a community and moves those who hear of it.

3. Can the landowners and community stay united? How will the company **divide and pay** some landowners against others, exploiting disputes over who speaks for the land — and can the community be held together? This is the decisive practical question.

4. Can the community reach legal aid and the environmental committee? Can you reach the **Public Solicitor's legal-aid unit** and environmental legal teams, and the **Environmental Advisory Committee**? These are how a remote community makes the law work, as Wagina did.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who is watching? Which officials granted the license and consent; who owns, funds, and profits from the proponent; which landowners and communities are affected and whether they can hold united; and which legal-aid, environmental, and international organisations, courts, press, and the wider public can be engaged. This maps your levers and your audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose a foreign company holds a license to log or mine on customary land, threatening the forest, the rivers, and the reefs the community fishes, on a "consent" obtained from a single staged meeting most landowners never attended.

Working the five questions: the decisive flaw is the **defective consent** — a staged meeting is not genuine free, prior, and informed consent, and that is the lever, as at Wagina. The harm — **the threat to the forest, rivers, and reefs the community lives on** — roots the fight. Can the **landowners stay united** against the company's payments and the disputes it will exploit? Can you reach **legal aid and the Environmental Advisory Committee**? And the deciders are the ministry and the Committee, with the courts, the international allies, and the press as pressure points.

Within a weekend you have moved from "we oppose the project" to a target list: challenge the faked consent; unite the landowners against division; document the harm to land and sea; reach legal aid and the environmental committee; draw international attention; and prepare for a long fight. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how Wagina stopped its mine. Notice what the exercise did: it converted a diffuse fear into a short list of concrete, assignable tasks — challenge the consent, unite the landowners, document the harm, reach legal aid and the Committee, draw the world — each tied to a specific lever and each of which can begin today. That is the difference the five questions make, and in the Solomon Islands the first of them, whether the consent was genuine, is the one that most often decides where the fight is won.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. The Environmental Advisory Committee, a judge, a legal-aid lawyer, an international organisation, and the community all move on evidence, not indignation. And in a system where consent is faked and impacts are hidden, a well-documented case is exactly what makes the law work. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Official Record and the Consent

Get the documents the decision rests on, and above all **the consent and the impact statement**. Obtain the **license**, the **development consent**, the **environmental impact statement** — which the company may have hidden, as at Wagina, itself a defect — and, critically, **the record of how the landowners' consent was claimed to be obtained**: the meetings, the signatures, who attended and who did not. Use requests, legal aid, and the environmental process to

obtain what is withheld; a refusal to share the impact statement is itself a powerful defect. The gap between what the paper claims — genuine consent, a disclosed assessment, a lawful license — and what actually happened is where cases are won. Give particular attention to reconstructing the truth of the consultation, because that is the ground on which a Solomon Islands case most often stands or falls: who called the meeting, who was told of it, who actually attended, what they were shown and what was kept from them, and whether those who signed had any customary authority to bind the land. A "consent" that dissolves under these questions — as Wagina's did — is the single most powerful thing a community can put before the Environmental Advisory Committee and the courts.

Layer 2: The Ground Truth

Document the reality the paper hides, and put the **land and sea** at the centre. Record the **forest, the rivers, the reefs, the fishing grounds, the gardens, and the seaweed farms** — what will be lost, and what the community depends on. Document the **scale** — the share of the island, the hectares of forest, the truckloads, the run-off into the sea — as Wagina documented that the mine would take sixty percent of the island. Photograph and date the **land and the site**, and capture **before-and-after**. Record the **consent fraud on the ground**: the landowners who never consented, the meeting most never attended, the signatures in doubt. Record **testimony** from landowners, fishers, and those who hold the customary knowledge of the land.

Layer 3: The Defects and the Dangers

Finally, document the failures and the dangers. Is the **consent faked, forced, hidden, or given by those without authority** over the land? Was the **environmental impact statement withheld** from the community — a defect that undid Wagina? Is the **assessment deficient**, understating the harm to the land, rivers, and sea? Was the **license granted corruptly**? Each defect is a separate ground — for challenging the consent, an environmental objection, a case to the Committee, a court challenge, and the public campaign — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Solomon Islands fights, because here a project that looked approved is revealed to rest on a consent that was never genuine and an impact hidden from the people — exactly the case that revoked the Wagina consent and dismissed the appeal.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Solomon Islands cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that expose your project's particular defect — most often, the defect in consent.

The Consent, License, and Their Paper Trail

- **The consent record** — how the landowners' agreement was claimed to be obtained: the meetings, the attendance, the signatures, and who among the true landowners never agreed. This is the heart of most cases.
- **The environmental impact statement** — obtain it; if the company **withheld it from the community**, that concealment is itself a defect, as at Wagina.
- **The license and development consent** — the grant, its terms, and whether the law's steps were followed.
- **The landowner and custom records** — who genuinely holds the land under custom, and whether those who "consented" had the authority.
- **The proponent and its money** — the company, its owners and financiers, and how it is paying and dividing landowners.

How to Get Them

License and consent records are held by the relevant ministries and the environmental authority; the impact statement should be public and given to the community. Much is withheld in a weak and sometimes corrupt system, so lean on **legal aid and allies**: the Public Solicitor's **Landowners Advocacy and Legal Support Unit**, environmental legal teams, and international organisations, who can obtain documents, reach the Environmental Advisory Committee, and protect the community — as they carried the Wagina case. Work with the **customary landowners and elders** on who truly holds and speaks for the land, because a disputed or false claim of authority is often the crux. Move early: challenging a defective consent and gathering the record before the license is entrenched and the payments have spread is worth far more than the same effort later.

The Ground Evidence

- **The land and forest** — the forest, gardens, and what clearing would destroy, mapped and testified.
- **The rivers and sea** — the reefs, the fishing grounds, the seaweed farms, and the run-off and contamination the project would bring.
- **The scale** — the share of the island, the hectares, the truckloads, the years, documented as Wagina documented sixty percent of the island.
- **The consent fraud** — the landowners who never agreed, the staged meeting, the doubtful signatures.
- **Dated, geotagged photographs and video** of the land, the sea, and the site.
- **Testimony** — from landowners, fishers, elders, and custom-knowledge holders.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the license, the claimed consent, the impact statement, and every step and deadline — the spine of any challenge, Committee case, or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a landowner, an elder, a legal-aid lawyer, the environmental committee, a journalist, an international organisation, and a judge all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the company's people challenge it. In a country where a case turns on whether consent was genuine, the community with the better-kept file — above all the clearest evidence of the consent fraud and the threat to land and sea — is very often the one that makes the law work, as Wagina did.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO UNITE THE LANDOWNERS AND COMMUNITY

Evidence and law do not stop projects on their own. United landowners and communities do — and in the Solomon Islands, holding the landowners together is the whole game, because a company's surest weapon is to **divide and pay** them. Wagina was won because its community stayed united through a seven-year fight and insisted, together, that it had never genuinely consented. A Solomon Islands campaign's strength is the unity of the customary landowners and the community, and its greatest enemy is the division a company engineers.

Phase 1: The Core, the Land, and Genuine Consent

Start with a small, committed core — five to fifteen people, including **customary landowners and elders** whose authority over the land roots the fight — and build the campaign around **genuine consent and the land and sea**. Assign roles: consent and license, documentation, legal-aid liaison, landowner unity, international liaison, and media. Agree on the goal — the consent revoked, the project stopped, the land and sea protected — and on what you will and will not accept. And plan, from the first day, for how the **company will try to divide and pay the landowners**.

Phase 2: Uniting the Landowners and the Community

Then the central task: **unite the true landowners and the community**, because the company will exploit every dispute over who speaks for the land and will pay some against others. Bring together the **customary landowners** — settling, as far as possible, who genuinely holds and speaks for the land, so the company cannot exploit a false or divided claim — the **whole community** whose livelihoods are at stake, the **neighbouring communities** who share the threat, the **churches and chiefs** whose authority helps hold people together, and the **legal-aid and environmental allies** who bring the law within reach. Name and counter the division openly: make the case that the money is temporary and the land is the community's life, that a divided community loses and a united one wins. Wagina held because its people stayed united in the truth that they had never consented — and that unity is the thing a Solomon Islands campaign must build and guard above all. Practically, this means confronting head-on the question the company will exploit — who genuinely holds and speaks for the land — and settling it, as far as custom allows, before the company can manufacture a false or divided answer. It means bringing the vulnerable and the tempted into the campaign with respect, giving everyone a role, and using the authority of elders, chiefs, and churches to frame acceptance of a payment as a betrayal of the whole community. The proponent will spend to open every crack; the campaign's task is to close them faster than the money can widen them.

A worked coalition example. Facing a mine or logging on customary land, the true landowners and elders form the rooted base, united on who speaks for the land; the community whose fishing and gardens are threatened joins as one; the churches and chiefs help hold it together against payment; and the Public Solicitor's legal-aid unit and environmental teams bring the law and the Environmental Advisory Committee within reach. No single group could have carried it; together they cover the land, the unity, the livelihoods, and the law — the model that stopped the Wagina mine.

Phase 3: Sustaining It Against Division and Time

Campaigns in the Solomon Islands die of two things: **division** and **the long wait**, and the company engineers both. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete, finishable tasks. Mark small wins — a united landowner statement, a document obtained, a Committee filing, an international statement. Rotate roles. But above all, **hold the unity**: watch for the payments and the disputes the company will use to split the landowners, answer them openly, and keep genuine consent and the land at the centre. And prepare for a **long fight** — Wagina took seven years — so build a community that can endure, because the company counts on the wait wearing you down. A community that stays united and endures, insisting it never consented, is a project's worst enemy.

Phase 4: Showing Strength

Numbers and unity must be seen. Turn the landowners and community out for meetings, hearings, and peaceful, well-run events, and let the **elders and true landowners** speak with one voice, so all can see a united community that never consented, not a divided one the company can pick apart. Make the harm to the land and sea, and the fraud in the consent, visible. The point is not spectacle; it is to demonstrate — to the ministry, the Environmental Advisory Committee, the courts, and the world — that the true landowners are united and did not agree, exactly as Wagina demonstrated until its consent was revoked and the appeal dismissed.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — CONSENT, THE COMMITTEE, AND THE COURTS

Solomon Islands law gives communities real and distinctive tools, and Wagina proved they can stop a mine the government approved. You do not need a final ruling to win with them: challenging a defective consent, a case to the Environmental Advisory Committee, or a court filing halts a project, forces disclosure, and creates leverage. Engage legal aid — the Public Solicitor's unit and environmental teams — early, because they make the law reachable, and understand the tools yourself.

Genuine Consent and Customary Land

The first and most powerful lever is **genuine consent**. Customary land needs the landowners' **free, prior, and informed consent**, and a consent that was **faked, forced, hidden, or given by those without authority** over the land is a fatal defect — the flaw that undid Wagina, where the company had never truly won the community's agreement and had hidden its impact statement. Establish exactly how consent was claimed to be obtained, expose the fraud, and make it the centre of your case, because in the Solomon Islands the defect in consent is the strongest ground a community holds.

The Environmental Advisory Committee

The second lever is the **Environmental Advisory Committee**. It can **refuse or revoke development consent** where the environmental law was not followed — including where consent was not obtained and the impact statement was hidden — and its decision can be defended on appeal to the **Minister of the Environment**. This is the body that revoked the Wagina consent and whose decision the Minister upheld, a first in the nation's history. Bring your case to it, with legal aid, and make the defect in consent and the hidden impact statement your grounds.

The Courts and Customary Rights

The third lever is the **courts**. The **High Court** and the courts can review the legality of licenses, consents, and decisions, and enforce customary-land rights. A well-built legal case forces disclosure, creates delay, builds the record, and can overturn a license or consent. Use the courts alongside the Committee and the community pressure, with legal aid, not instead of them.

Legal Aid and International Allies

Finally, the levers that make the others reachable: **legal aid and international allies**. The Public Solicitor's **Landowners Advocacy and Legal Support Unit** and environmental legal teams work for communities, so a remote and poor community can reach the Committee and the courts — as Wagina did. And international organisations, drawn by the Pacific's ecology and by how communities are treated, bring scrutiny and pressure that reach the company and the government. In a system where enforcement is weak, legal aid and international attention are often what turn a right on

paper into a right that works. This is a point of real hope for the poorest and most remote community, because it means that lack of money need not be the barrier it seems. The Public Solicitor's office exists to represent those who cannot pay, its landowner-support unit specialises in exactly these fights, and environmental legal teams and international programs stand ready to help carry a case to the Committee and the courts. The people of Wagina did not win because they were wealthy or well-connected; they won because they reached the legal help that was there for them and used it with determination.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Consent and license challenges and customary-rights cases go to the **courts**; environmental challenges to the **Environmental Advisory Committee** and, on appeal, the **Minister**; and the whole is made reachable through **legal aid** — the Public Solicitor's unit and environmental teams — and **international allies**. Get help early: these legal-aid and environmental bodies know the consent law, the Committee, the courts, and the strongest ground, and can carry a remote community's case, as they carried Wagina's. Help engaged while the consent is contestable, and before the payments divide the landowners, is worth far more than help sought after the doors have closed — and in the Solomon Islands, the strongest strategy marries the defect in consent to united landowners, legal aid, and the Environmental Advisory Committee.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades the Environmental Advisory Committee, a judge, an international organisation, a journalist, and your own community in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a campaign reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a mine was approved for sixty percent of the island on a consent obtained from one staged meeting most landowners never attended, with the impact statement hidden from the community. That one fact becomes:

- **A consent argument (the strongest):** the landowners never gave free, prior, and informed consent, and the impact statement was hidden — the defect that undid Wagina.
- **A legal argument:** the development consent was granted unlawfully, without genuine consent and proper disclosure — grounds for the Committee and the courts.
- **A livelihoods argument (to the community and nation):** the mine would destroy the island and the sea two thousand people live on — the argument that unites and rouses.
- **An international argument:** a foreign company would clear a Pacific island's forest and reefs without the people's consent — the argument that draws the world.
- **A media argument:** a company taking sixty percent of an island on a faked consent, and hiding the harm — a vivid, resonant story.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in the Solomon Islands the argument that most often decides things is the **consent** one, because a faked or hidden consent is the legal flaw that stops a project, followed by the **livelihoods** one that unites the community. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a journalist can be backed in the file and a claim made to the Committee can be proven, because consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The Environmental Advisory Committee and the courts want the illegality framed precisely — the absence of genuine consent, the hidden impact statement, the unlawful license — with the documents and the timeline that prove it.

Your own community and the landowners need the consent-and-livelihoods argument above all — we never agreed, and this is the island and sea we live on — because unity is the precondition for everything. This is the argument to make most often and most carefully, in the words and through the authorities the community trusts — the elders, the chiefs, the churches — because it is aimed not at persuading outsiders but at holding the landowners themselves against the steady pressure of the company's offers. Every other argument in the campaign depends on this one landing: a community convinced that its land and sea are worth more than any payment is a community that can hold the line long enough to win.

Journalists need a specific, verified, human story with a hook: a named island and community, a documented threat, a faked consent, and a live decision.

International organisations respond to the ecology at stake and the denial of the community's consent — the two things about a Pacific fight the world most readily takes up.

The Minister and the government, in the end, respond to the pressure all of these create — a united community, a clear legal defect, and the world's scrutiny — as the Minister did at Wagina.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and for a remote community facing a captured process, national and international attention is often what makes the law work. Coverage raises the political cost of a project, reaches the Minister and the government over the heads of captured officials, draws the world to a Pacific community and its ecosystem, and protects a community by making its fight visible. Wagina's win was amplified by exactly this: the international attention to a tiny island community facing a mine that would take most of its home helped make the fight impossible to ignore.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named place and stake, a documented threat, and a live decision. "A project threatens the environment" is not a story; "a foreign company would take sixty percent of an island two thousand people live on, on a consent it faked and an impact statement it hid" is. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the scale, the faked consent, and the threat to the land and sea — and offer a human story: a landowner, an elder, a fisher. In the Solomon Islands the story of an island community defending its land and sea against a foreign company and a faked consent is uniquely powerful at home and abroad.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first. Then the **national outlets** — the Solomon Islands' press and radio — which carry the story to the nation and the government; in a fight decided at the national level, this ring is essential. Then, crucially, the **international networks and media** — the environmental and human-rights organisations and the regional and world press drawn by a Pacific community's fight — which bring a scrutiny and reach a weak domestic system cannot match, and which reach the company's owners and financiers abroad. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. In the Solomon Islands the **international ring is unusually powerful**, because the world takes up the cause of a Pacific island community defending its home. The story of Wagina reached far beyond the Solomon Islands precisely because it was so stark — a tiny island community, a foreign company, a mine that would consume most of their home — and that international attention brought the scrutiny of environmental and human-rights organisations to bear on the government's decision and the company's conduct. For a remote community whose own government may be inclined toward the project, the ability to make the wider world care is not a luxury but often the decisive addition to the domestic legal fight.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions. Plan a sequence — the faked consent, the scale, the threat to land and sea, the hidden impact statement — so there is always a next hook, and document everything so the story can be told and defended. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; a single exaggeration handed to the company can cost credibility, especially with international allies who must vouch for you. And keep telling the story through a long fight and after a win, because a company may seek to revive a project or challenge a decision. Verified, specific, consent-and-livelihoods-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped a tiny island community stop a mine the government had approved.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you object, demand, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — including the legal-aid and international allies that make the law reachable. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet

most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in consent, the land and sea, and the law.

8A. Challenge to Defective Consent

To: the relevant ministry / the Environmental Advisory Committee (via legal aid) **Subject:** [Project] rests on a consent the landowners never gave

We, the customary landowners of [place], submit that [project] rests on a **defective consent**: the landowners never gave free, prior, and informed consent — [the meeting was staged / most never attended / those who "consented" had no authority over the land] — and the company **hid its environmental impact statement** from us. We attach our evidence. We ask that the consent and development consent be **refused or revoked**, as they were for the Wagina mine.

8B. Case to the Environmental Advisory Committee

To: the Environmental Advisory Committee (via legal aid) **Subject:** Objection to development consent — [project] at [location]

We object to the development consent for [project]. Our grounds, with evidence: (1) the landowners' **consent was not genuinely obtained**; (2) the **environmental impact statement was withheld** from the community; (3) the assessment understates the harm to [the forest / rivers / reefs / fishing]; (4) the law's steps were not followed. We request that consent be **refused or revoked**, and stand ready to defend that decision on appeal.

8C. Request to Legal Aid (Public Solicitor / Environmental Team)

To: the Public Solicitor's Landowners Advocacy and Legal Support Unit / an environmental legal team **Subject:** [Project] on our customary land — request for legal support

We, the landowners of [place], face [project] on our customary land, approved on a **consent we never gave** and with **the impact statement hidden** from us. We attach what we have. We seek your support to **challenge the consent**, bring a case to the **Environmental Advisory Committee**, and, if needed, the **courts** — as your work carried the Wagina case. We also seek help obtaining the documents and reaching international allies.

8D. Appeal to International Environmental / Human-Rights Networks

To: [an environmental or human-rights organisation] **Subject:** Threat to [island/community] and denial of consent — Solomon Islands

We write regarding [project] at [location], which would [one-line stake — e.g. "clear the forest and reefs of an island two thousand people live on"], approved on a **consent the community never gave**. We attach our evidence, including the scale and the consent fraud. We ask you to bring your scrutiny and networks to bear — with the government, the company's owners, and the world — as international attention helped the people of Wagina stop their mine.

8E. Letter to the Company's Owners / Financiers

To: [the company / its parent / financier] **Subject:** [Project] — legal, reputational, and consent risk

We write regarding your [ownership of / investment in] [company] and [project] at [location]. The project [one-line stake], and it rests on a **consent the customary landowners never gave** and an **impact statement hidden** from them. We remind you that the people of Wagina Island had a bauxite mine's consent revoked and the company's appeal dismissed on exactly such defects. We ask you to weigh the legal, reputational, and consent risk, and we are glad to share our evidence.

8F. Letter to the Minister / the Government

To: the Minister of the Environment / the relevant ministry **Subject:** [Project] at [location] — request to refuse or revoke consent

We are the customary landowners and community of [place], writing about [project], approved on a **consent we never gave**, which threatens the **land and sea we live on**. We ask you to **refuse or revoke** the development consent, as the Minister did for the Wagina bauxite mine. We attach our evidence of the defective consent and the harm, and welcome the chance to be heard.

8G. Email to a Reporter (National or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the island / the community]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something your readers should know, with a clear hook: [documents and evidence] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a foreign company would take sixty percent of an island two thousand people live on, on a faked consent"], with [a decision] due [date]. It echoes how Wagina Island stopped its mine. I can share the full file and connect you with landowners, an elder, and a fisher. Could we talk this week?

8H. Community / Landowner Statement

To: the government and the public (as a united statement) **Subject:** We, the landowners of [place], did not consent to [project]

We, the customary landowners and community of [place], declare with one voice that we **did not give our free, prior, and informed consent** to [project], which would destroy the **land and sea we live on**. This is our customary land and our life, and no staged meeting or payment is our consent. We call on the government to refuse or revoke the consent, and on all Solomon Islanders and the world to stand with us — as the people of Wagina stood, and won.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable where you can, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a challenge to consent, a withheld impact statement, and a demand refused is itself evidence, and exactly what the Committee, the courts, and the press will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in consent, the land and sea, and the law; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through legal aid, the environmental and international organisations, and the national and international press. The reply, or the decision, becomes part of your record, and in the Solomon Islands that record feeds the levers that matter most: united landowners, the defect in consent, legal aid, and the Environmental Advisory Committee.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Establish and challenge the consent.** In the Solomon Islands, a **faked, forced, or hidden consent** is the flaw that stops a project. Establish how "consent" was claimed, and challenge it as the centre of your fight (8A, 8H).
- 2. Unite the landowners.** The company's surest weapon is to divide and pay the landowners; hold them together, settling who truly speaks for the land, because unity is everything (8H).
- 3. Reach legal aid.** The Public Solicitor's legal-aid unit and environmental teams make the law reachable for a remote community, and can carry your case (8C) — as they carried Wagina's.
- 4. Bring it to the Environmental Advisory Committee.** The Committee can revoke a development consent, as it did at Wagina (8B).
- 5. Get the impact statement.** If the company hid it, that concealment is itself a defect (8A, 8C).
- 6. Reach international allies.** An appeal to environmental and human-rights networks (8D) brings the world's scrutiny — powerful in a weak state.
- 7. Reach the press.** A vivid consent-and-livelihoods story (8G) carries the fight to the nation and the world.

Do only the first three and you will have challenged the consent, united the landowners, and reached the legal aid that makes the law work — the exact foundation on which Wagina won. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: challenge the consent, unite the landowners, reach legal aid. Those three moves are exactly the ones that, done from the start, put the decisive Solomon Islands levers into play — a defect in consent the law cannot ignore, a community the company cannot divide, and the legal aid that carries a remote people to the Environmental Advisory Committee — and they are within reach of a determined group of landowners with their elders, their unity, and a few letters to the right allies.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The Solomon Islands' system is tilted steeply, and you must understand how, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is severe, and honesty demands naming it. The deepest is **non-enforcement and corruption**, above all in the **logging industry**: licenses are granted on a single staged meeting, consent is faked, chiefs and landowners are divided and paid, and thousands of kilometres of logging roads have been driven through the forests at a ruinous, unsustainable pace with little regard for the law on the books. **Communities are divided** — companies exploit disputes over who speaks for the land and pay some landowners against others. The **state is weak and remote**, and a community far from the capital struggles to reach the law without help. And wins are **hard-won and rare** — Wagina took seven years and turned on a clear defect not every project has. Where these tilts bite, the law on paper gives little on its own — but, used well and insisted upon, it can still be made to work.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even where the system tilts steeply, real and distinctive levers remain.

Genuine consent still cannot be faked without risk. Wagina proved that a consent the landowners never gave is a defect that can undo a project, even one the government approved.

The Environmental Advisory Committee still bites. It revoked the Wagina consent, and the Minister upheld it — a channel that can stop a project where the law was not followed.

Legal aid still reaches the remote. The Public Solicitor's unit and environmental teams carried Wagina and can carry others, making the law reachable for the poorest community.

The world still watches. International attention to a Pacific community and its ecosystem reaches the government and the company over a captured process.

Unity still wins. A community that holds its landowners together and insists it never consented is the one thing the company's division cannot overcome.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for the Solomon Islands is hard, and this guide will not pretend otherwise. Corruption, non-enforcement, division, and a weak remote state are severe obstacles, and a divided community rarely wins. But a **united community, insisting on genuine consent and using legal aid to reach the Environmental Advisory Committee**, can stop a project — as Wagina did. So diagnose your fight honestly: challenge the **defective consent**; unite the **landowners** against division above all; reach **legal aid and the Committee**; make the **land-and-sea-livelihoods** argument; draw the **world's attention**; and prepare for a **long fight**. Where the landowners are divided and the process captured, aim at delay, scrutiny, and the record — and remember that a tiny island community, united and insisting it never consented, stopped a mine the government had approved.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

In the Solomon Islands, corruption is not the exception but often the terrain, especially in logging, so this section is central. When a project advances through faked consent, paid chiefs, a license granted despite the law, and officials aligned with the company, you stop trying to persuade a captured decision-maker and start exposing and going around them.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture, which here are common. A **consent claimed from a single staged meeting** most landowners never attended; **some chiefs or landowners paid** to support the project and speak against their community; a **license granted despite an obvious threat and a defective consent**; the **impact statement withheld**; and **officials aligned** with the company. Trace the money and the consent: who was paid, and how the

"consent" was manufactured. One anomaly may be error; in the Solomon Islands, a faked consent, paid landowners, and a license pushed through against the law is the ordinary shape of a captured logging or mining deal, and should be assumed possible until the process proves itself clean.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where undue influence reaches. **Some officials, some chiefs and landowners, and parts of the process** can be paid or aligned. But even here, some bodies and audiences are far harder to capture: the **Environmental Advisory Committee** and the **courts**, when a clear defect is put before them; the **Public Solicitor's legal-aid unit and environmental teams**, who work for communities; the **international organisations and press**, beyond any local interest; and — decisively — a **community of true landowners united in the truth that they never consented**, which no payment can fully divide. Capture thrives on the faked consent and the paid split; your task is to hold the unity, expose the fraud, and lift the matter to the Committee, the courts, and the world.

What to Do

Do not confront and tip off a captured decision-maker. Instead, **hold your landowners united and document the fraud** — the staged meeting, the paid chiefs, the hidden impact statement, the license against the law — and take it, with legal aid, to the audiences beyond its control: the **Environmental Advisory Committee** and the **courts**, the **international organisations and press**, and the **Minister**, who at Wagina dismissed the company's appeal. Pair the exposure with the consent and livelihoods case, so the corruption and the harm surface together. And guard the landowners' unity above all, because in the Solomon Islands corruption's chief weapon is the division of the landowners: a community whose true landowners cannot be split, and who insist together that they never consented, is a community a captured process cannot easily defeat.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in the Solomon Islands turns first and last on united landowners insisting on genuine consent, and may take years, as Wagina did.

Early (Weeks 0-8): Consent, Unity, and Legal Aid

Pin down the project, the license, and — first — **how the consent was claimed and what the project does to the land and sea** (Step 1). Unite the **core and the landowners** around genuine consent and the land (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **challenge the defective consent** (8A, 8H); **unite the landowners** against division; **reach legal aid** — the Public Solicitor's unit and environmental teams (8C); and **bring a case to the Environmental Advisory Committee** and **get the impact statement** (8B). Begin **documenting** the harm and the consent fraud (Step 2). This phase lays the foundation, and in the Solomon Islands the consent challenge and the unity begun here are what ultimately win.

Middle (Months 2-24): Escalate on Every Front, Hold the Unity

Widen the coalition while **guarding the landowners' unity** against division and payment (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Escalate as the facts warrant — the **Environmental Advisory Committee case**, the **court challenge**, and the **international and company appeals** (Step 4). Build the media drumbeat from local to national to international (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — challenge the consent, hold the unity, reach the Committee — because a broken unity is the one loss that cannot be undone. And sequence the rest so each lands when it bites hardest — the demand for the hidden impact statement made early, so its concealment becomes a documented defect; the Committee case built while the consent is freshly contestable; the international appeal timed to a decision the world will notice — because in the Solomon Islands a fight is won by those who hold their landowners united, insist on genuine consent, and use legal aid and outside attention to make a captured process obey its own law.

Later (Months 6+, Often Years): The Revoked Consent, and Holding It

Sustain the unity and the case and the attention; keep the record alive through a long fight. Pursue what is achievable — the **consent revoked, the project stopped, the land and sea protected**, as at Wagina — and, against a divided community or a captured process, the **delay, scrutiny, and record** that are the realistic gains. And be ready to **defend the win** — a company may appeal, as Solomon Bauxite did, only to have the Minister dismiss it. Judge success honestly.

Sometimes it is a consent revoked and a mine stopped, as at Wagina. Sometimes it is a project delayed and scrutinised while the landowners hold. Both are victories worth the fight.

The Shape of a Campaign

WEEKS 0-8	Challenge the consent Unite the landowners Reach legal aid Case to the Environmental Advisory Committee
MONTHS 2-24	Widen + GUARD the unity Arguments Committee + courts + international + company National & international media
MONTHS 6+	The revoked consent / the appeal Win a revoke / stop / delay DEFEND it, hold the landowners united

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Solomon Islands give communities real and distinctive strengths, and also confront them with some of the severest obstacles in this guide, and the honest measure of it is how squarely it faces both.

The strengths are real and distinctive. **Customary land and genuine consent** are the foundation — a project needs the landowners' free, prior, and informed consent, and a faked or hidden consent is a fatal defect, as it was at Wagina. The **Environmental Advisory Committee** can revoke a development consent, and the Minister upheld it. **Legal aid** — the Public Solicitor's unit and environmental teams — makes the law reachable for the poorest, most remote community. The **land-and-sea livelihoods** root the fight in survival itself. And **international allies** bring a scrutiny that reaches a captured process. These are the levers that let a tiny island community stop a mine its government had approved.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them plainly because in the Solomon Islands they are grave. **Non-enforcement and corruption**, above all in logging, mean the law on paper is often ignored. **Communities are divided** by payment and dispute over who speaks for the land. The **state is weak and remote**. And wins are **hard-won and rare** — Wagina took seven years. No guide should pretend these away; here, the fight is above all to unite the landowners and make the law work.

So the realistic promise is this: **challenge the defective consent; unite the landowners against division; reach legal aid and the Environmental Advisory Committee; make the land-and-sea-livelihoods argument; draw international attention; prepare for a long fight; and defend the win — running all of it together.** Do that, and against a project built on a faked or hidden consent, with the landowners united, you can have the consent revoked and the project stopped, as Wagina did; against a divided community or a captured process, you can delay, scrutinise, and build the record that wins the next round. Do it as the people of Wagina did — an island community that stayed united through seven years, insisted it had never consented, used legal aid to reach the Environmental Advisory Committee, and stopped a mine that would have taken most of its home.

A last word on unity and endurance. The Solomon Islands' great lesson is that a united community of customary landowners, insisting on the genuine consent that was never given and using legal aid to reach the law, can stop a project its own government approved — and that the one thing that can defeat it is the division a company engineers by paying some landowners against others. The company counts on that division, on the faked consent passing unchallenged, on the corruption of the process, and on the long wait wearing you down. Its advantage is money, and a system that too often ignores its own law. Yours is the deepest advantage a community can have — customary land that is your life, a right to consent that was never given, legal aid that makes the law reachable, and the proven power of landowners who stay united and insist on the truth. Play to that. Keep the file and the record of the consent fraud, keep genuine consent and the land and sea at the centre, keep the landowners united above all, reach legal aid and the Committee, draw the world's eyes, and treat every challenge to a faked consent, every document obtained, every Committee filing, and every year the landowners hold together as a brick in a wall no company's money can climb — and that a united community can hold against every appeal.

The tools are here, and the Solomon Islands themselves proved them: a tiny island community, with nothing but its unity and the law properly used, stopped a bauxite mine its own government had approved, a first in the nation's history. What decides the outcome, in the end, is method, endurance, and landowners united in the truth that they never consented — and those you supply. Begin today, begin with the consent and the unity that protects the land, and build from there. Communities before you have revoked, stopped, and overturned what looked unstoppable — a consent revoked, a mine stopped, an island home defended by the people who live on it. What was won at Wagina — by an island community that stayed united through seven long years, insisted with one voice that it had never truly consented, reached the legal aid that made the law work, and had a mine's consent revoked and the company's appeal dismissed — can be won again by any community that unites its landowners, challenges a consent that was never genuine, and refuses to be worn down. What was won at Wagina can be won again. So can yours.